# Reflecting on two reading lessons

Charlotte's Web and The Outsiders · Katherine Conklin

## Lesson 1: Charlotte's Web, vocabulary in context

The strategies for using context clues to understand vocabulary were chosen because they are directly aligned with ELA Standard 5.4. The use of a passage from *Charlotte's Web* was intentional, as the story's themes and characters are age-appropriate and resonate with students' imaginative interests. The vocabulary words, "radiant," "humbly," and "summon," were selected to be both challenging and meaningful within the context of the story. This approach mirrored the students' everyday literacies by encouraging them to think about how words are used in stories they might encounter at home or in their communities. The guided discussion on context clues helped bridge academic vocabulary skills with real-world reading experiences, such as interpreting stories or instructions. The materials, including the worksheet and whiteboard, provided both individual and collective opportunities to analyze and discuss words in context.

### What went well

The guided reading and class discussion segments went well. Students were eager to share their interpretations of the vocabulary words, especially when encouraged to look for clues in the text. For example, when discussing the word "radiant," many students connected it to the description of Charlotte's web glistening in the sunlight. Their responses demonstrated a strong ability to infer meanings using context.

### What I would change

Similar to the phonological awareness lesson, most students found the vocabulary words relatively easy to decode using context clues. While they enjoyed the discussion, the worksheet did not challenge some of the more advanced learners, leading to faster completion and less engagement for those students. Additionally, a few students struggled to articulate their reasoning for definitions, even though they could guess meanings accurately. In the future, I would incorporate more complex vocabulary or extend the activity to include creating their own sentences using the new words. I could also pair students to discuss and critique each other's reasoning before sharing with the class. Overall, the lesson achieved its goals, but adding complexity and collaboration would enhance the learning experience next time.

## Lesson 2: The Outsiders, character traits and resilience

The strategies of analyzing character traits and using a character map were chosen because they align with ELA Standard 5.8, which emphasizes understanding character development over the course of a text. The excerpt from *The Outsiders* was selected because it portrays a dramatic and emotionally impactful moment, engaging students while providing rich material for analysis. Resilience, a central theme in the scene, connects to students' lives and broader societal discussions. The lesson mirrors students' everyday literacies by focusing on resilience, a concept they can relate to through personal challenges or familiar figures such as athletes or historical icons. For example, the discussion prompts encouraged students to draw parallels between Ponyboy's bravery and real-life examples, such as Rosa Parks or Jackie

Robinson. This connection fostered deeper engagement and made the lesson more relevant. Materials such as the character map graphic organizer helped structure their analysis, making it accessible to students of varying skill levels.

**What went well**

The guided reading and group discussion went exceptionally well. Students were captivated by the vivid imagery in the excerpt and eager to discuss Ponyboy's actions during the fire. Many connected Ponyboy's traits, bravery and selflessness, to their own experiences or values, which added depth to the discussion. The character map allowed students to organize their thoughts effectively, and most were able to complete it with minimal guidance.

**What I would change**

Some students struggled with the independent reflection activity. While they could identify Ponyboy's traits and actions, articulating their own experiences with resilience required additional support. Advanced learners also completed the character map quickly and could have benefited from an extension activity. Next time, I would provide sentence stems or a collaborative brainstorming session before the reflection activity to scaffold students' responses. For advanced learners, I would include a comparative analysis task, such as evaluating resilience in different characters from other stories or films. Overall, the students were highly engaged, and the lesson successfully highlighted the importance of character development and resilience.